



iCarbon

An iPhone app designed by an Indian developer - Raghavendra Rathore
- calculates your individual carbon footprint

Dangerous driving

26% of mobile users SMS while driving.
Majority of them are youngsters

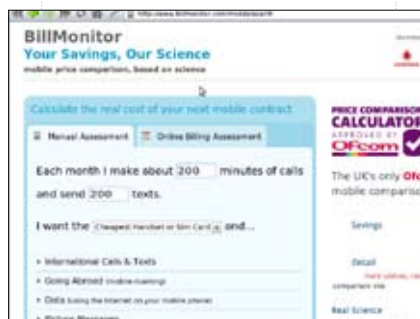
risk' by McAfee since the worm activity only reduced battery life. The next batch of viruses may not be so harmless.

For a virus to be spread through Bluetooth, it needs to be within a 10 to 30 metre radius of another Bluetooth-enabled phone. MMS proliferating viruses are not so restricted in their spread. Like computer viruses, they spread using the address book of the device and a network connection. The bad news is that hybrid viruses are also conceivable and these will pose the most significant threat. An interesting finding of the study showed that while Bluetooth viruses will eventually spread to all phones, their progress will be slow. This is because it depends on human behavioural and mobility patterns. So the spread will be just like an actual medical disease outbreak. This brings a glimmer of hope, since there would be ample time to deploy counter measures like antivirus. Studies such as this one are classified under computational social

science. They not only help in increasing the state of preparedness, but also help us find naturally occurring patterns in human behaviour.

Mobile bill advisor

Lets face it – with the multitude of plans and deals that cell phone companies offer, the confusion caused is limitless. Which plan do you opt for? Which service provider do you choose? Could you save a little on your bills by choosing something else? These questions always frustrate all of us to wits end. Most times you go by what a friend advises or by what you believe is the best plan depending on your usage pattern. But don't you wish there was a scientific way to make an informed decision? Well, it looks like there is



hope. Mathematicians and scientific advisers from Oxford University have helped develop a price comparison web site for mobile phone users. Of course, the web site and tool caters only to the UK mobile market, but something similar or based on it could easily be adapted for India. The web site – BillMonitor – is accredited by the communications regulator, Ofcom. The UK market seems to be highly complex as it offers consumers over three million deals on over 1,19,078 tariffs. But the web site considers only a few of the plans on offer. Consumers supply their bill details and the web site churns out a

recommendation. It makes money off the recommendation, but doesn't charge the consumers anything. In UK too, numerous complaints related to cell phones and other services such as broadband and digital television are received. Ofcom, the regulator, has previously accredited web sites in these sectors too. Maybe the TRAI could take a cue and launch an unbiased web site for us too.

Calling vs. SMS

It seems there is a great divide about what people prefer – calling or messaging. People's attitudes and preferences in this regard vary greatly from country to country and even region to region. Take the case of the US. Nielsen mobile recently announced that in the last quarter of 2008, the

average US cellphone user sent and received 447 texts in comparison to just 195 calls. The situation in other countries is far more skewed. A recent survey found that Filipinos have not made or received a single call in a period of three months. Instead, they preferred to SMS, while 86 per cent of Indians had made or received a call in the same period. The reason behind this could be economic as well as cultural. In this part of the world, an SMS costs as much as a call, (Re. 1 for local and around Rs.1.50 for STD), add to that the fact that as a people, we prefer to talk. Heck we love to talk so why not make a call when it's going to cost the same?! Calling also differs when it comes to gender. You might be right to think that women would much prefer to call than SMS. This same study also analysed non-cell phone calling patterns. It found that attitudes of women differ between countries too. Pakistani women, for instance, hardly ever use public phone booths, while women in India are more confident about public spaces. Stranger still is the mobile culture in Africa. There it is common to have one phone, but many SIM cards. One card is kept for SMSing, one card is good for receiving calls, while another may be used for calling one place and one card is reserved for a particular coverage in a particular area.

The old favourite 6600 is back!

Just the name 6600 brings back memories of days gone by, when the egg-like phone was the hottest new device in town. Ever since its launch, the phone had quickly

gained immense popularity. It was perhaps the first precursor of a smartphone that anyone had seen. So naturally when Nokia recently announced the return of the good old dependable handset in a new avatar 6600i, we were quite excited. It better match up to its older cousin was our first thought. In the looks department, it passes muster. On first look, the phone looks quite stunning – thanks to the brushed steel body it sports. The black version doesn't look that good though. The phone's got nice contours and a slide out keypad. The design has that



simplicity, yet elegant appeal that makes it more stylish than other flashy models. With a 5 MP camera with 8x zoom and dual-LED flash, the phone is designed for imaging and sharing. It is supposed to be the manufacturer's smallest 5 MP slider offering. But the phone might disappoint when it comes to what it is. Or rather what it is not. It's not a smartphone – it's just another Series 40 phone with a good camera.

For it to hold a candle to the old 6600 and the place it has in our heart, it should've had at least something revolutionary. It does feature touch technology, but most likely, it's limited to tasks such as answering or silencing calls. Other than an impressive camera, it's got a microSD slot expandable to 16 GB, 3G support, and a bright 2.2-inch 240x320 TFT 16-million colour display. It can record video at in VGA at 15 fps and QVGA at 30 fps. The phone is supposed to be specially built to make better use of Nokia's Ovi products. You won't have to wait too long to get a feel of it since its slated to be available in the third quarter of 2009 for 200 Euros (around Rs. 13,000). **A**

